



Guidelines for Relationship Effectiveness: Keeping the Relationship (GIVE)

A way to remember these skills is to remember the word **GIVE (DEAR MAN, GIVE):**

(Be) **G**entle
(Act) **I**nterested
Validate

(Use an) **E**asy manner

(Be)

Gentle

BE NICE and respectful.

No attacks: No verbal or physical attacks. No hitting, clenching fists. No harassment of any kind. Express anger directly with words.

No threats: If you have to describe painful consequences for not getting what you want, describe them calmly and without exaggerating.
No “manipulative” statements, no hidden threats. No “I’ll kill myself if you . . .”
Tolerate a “no.” Stay in the discussion even if it gets painful. Exit gracefully.

No judging: No moralizing. No “If you were a good person, you would . . .”
No “You should . . .” or “You shouldn’t . . .” Abandon blame.

No sneering: No smirking, eye rolling, sucking teeth. No cutting off or walking away.
No saying, “That’s stupid, don’t be sad,” “I don’t care what you say.”

(Act)

Interested

LISTEN and APPEAR INTERESTED in the other person.

Listen to the other person’s point of view.

Face the person; maintain eye contact; lean toward the person rather than away. Don’t interrupt or talk over the person.

Be sensitive to the person’s wish to have the discussion at a later time. Be patient.

Validate

With WORDS AND ACTIONS, show that you understand the other person’s feelings and thoughts about the situation. See the world from the other person’s point of view, and then say or act on what you see.

“I realize this is hard for you, and . . .”, “I see that you are busy, and . . .”

Go to a private place when the person is uncomfortable talking in a public place.

(Use an)

Easy manner

Use a little humor.

SMILE. Ease the person along. Be light-hearted. Sweet-talk.

Use a “soft sell” over a “hard sell.” Be “political.”

Leave your attitude at the door.

Other ideas:
